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CONSTANT COMPANION Children weren't left behind in the mad rush for computers, seeing them pop up in schools, libraries as well as their living rooms

> "It was like searching for a needle in a haystack. After the February 27 budget, stockbrokers were driven crazy by buyers looking for software stocks, none of which were on sale. The star scrips of the industry, already trading in four-figure prices, surged by more than Rs 100. Even small-cap software stocks... zoomed like rockets, hitting the 8 per cent ceiling on daily increase within minutes of trading. The big-ticket stocks followed soon. By March 3... the NSE had to repeatedly apply the circuit-breaker on most of the software stocks."



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interface was prone to rancour too; on cue, the Telecom Disputes Settlement and Appellate Tribunal (TDSAT) was born in 2000.

A decisive inflection point was the New Telecom Policy of 1999. Shifting from prohibitively high fixed licence fees to a revenue-sharing regime, it lowered entry barriers and enhanced financial viability. Investment surged, and India began its march toward becoming one of the world's largest—and cheapest—mobile markets.

As it happened, Digital India was timed fortuitously for Y2K. Computers worldwide were scrambling to fix date-format vulnerabilities, and Indian software drones—bilingually fluent in English and COBOL—became indispensable. Indian firms handled coding, testing and remediation at scale. The software and IT-enabled services story got off to a robust start, with revenues of $8.3 billion by 2000-01. The entire outsourcing sector blossomed as western firms sought reliable, low-cost talent. By 2005, the foundations for the digital powerhouse that India would later become had been laid. ■